

Gender, Theological Battles, and Power: The Importance of The Church of Hagios Sergius and Bacchus

Ben Crotteau

Serdar Yalçın

Art and Architecture of Byzantium and Medieval Europe

28 April 2024

The Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus (now called the Little Hagia Sophia mosque or Küçük Ayasofya) is a symbol of Byzantine architecture, religion, and imperialism. It is also a synthesis of Islamic and Christian visual style that resulted from the conquest of Constantinople by the Ottoman Empire in 1453 after nearly a millennium of Byzantine control, but the focus of the following analysis will be its significance in its original context. Located on the northeastern coast of the Sea of Marmara in southern Constantinople (now Istanbul), the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus was commissioned by the imperial couple Justinian I and Theodora who also ordered the construction of the Hagia Sophia.¹ Examination and analysis of the church and its historical context reveal three results. First, aristocratic women played a significant part in the construction of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus which reveals the role of gender in Byzantine Christianity and politics. Second, the church highlights controversial theological debates taking place throughout the eastern Mediterranean during Late Antiquity. Third, in comparison with the Hagia Sophia, it is clear that the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus and other acts of patronage expressed political and imperial power. These results reflect the social, political, and religious landscape of Late Antiquity in Byzantium.

The two leading theories for the motivation behind construction arise from the political context of the time period and its physical location, respectively. First, art historians such as Brian Croke have argued that “Justinian’s political rivalry with Anicia Juliana in the early to mid-520s” was the primary factor underlying the construction of the new church.² Juliana was an

¹ John Meyendorff. “Justinian, the Empire and the Church,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 22 (1968): 43–60, doi: 10.2307/1291275; “Constantinople, Church of SS. Sergius and Bacchus,” Livius.org, Modified 22 September 2020, <https://www.livius.org/articles/place/constantinople-istanbul/constantinople-photos/constantinople-church-of-ss-sergius-and-bacchus/>

² Brian Croke. “Justinian, Theodora, and the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 60 (2006): 25–63. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25046210>; Diliانا N Angelova. “CHURCH BUILDING AND FOUNDING,” *Sacred Founders: Women, Men, and Gods in the Discourse of Imperial Founding, Rome through Early Byzantium* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2015), <http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1525/j.ctt19632rv.16>.

aristocrat whom Croke portrayed as “Constantinople’s most distinguished woman”, and Justinian was not yet emperor.³ Juliana was the patron of many pieces of religious art and architecture, including the Church of Saint Polyeuktos in the 510s, the largest worship building in Constantinople until the Hagia Sophia was built in 537.⁴ Juliana was from the genealogical line of the Emperor Theodosius, Constantine’s successor and second ruler after the Roman Empire shifted its center to Constantinople from 379 to 395.⁵ Therefore, Juliana and her sons were a natural rival for Justinian who sought to ascend to the throne succeeding his uncle, Emperor Justin I.⁶ The dedication of the church to Saint Sergius was thus a deliberate choice by Justinian to outdo Juliana as Saint Polyeuktos was of lesser significance.⁷ Such a selection was necessary to combat the impressive “imperial genealogy” of Juliana that was referenced in the dedicatory inscription of the Church of Saint Polyeuktos and establish himself and his influence in the power structure of Byzantium.⁸ Additionally, references to Justinian and Theodora’s “piety” in the inscription of the Church of Hagios Sergius and Bacchus (Figure 3) can be compared to those references to Juliana in her church.⁹ This can be seen as a discourse created by Justinian to respond to the Church of Saint Polyeuktos and reinforce the idea that he embodied Christian values to gain social and political influence.¹⁰ Justinian’s rivalry with Juliana that may have led

³ Dilia N. Angelova. “CHURCH BUILDING AND FOUNDING,” *Sacred Founders: Women, Men, and Gods in the Discourse of Imperial Founding, Rome through Early Byzantium* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2015), <http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1525/j.ctt19632rv.16>; Brian Croke. “Justinian, Theodora, and the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 60 (2006): 25–63. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25046210>.

⁴ Carolyn L. Connor. “THE EPIGRAM IN THE CHURCH OF HAGIOS POLYEUKTOS IN CONSTANTINOPLE AND ITS BYZANTINE RESPONSE,” *Byzantion* 69, no. 2 (1999): 479–527, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/44172500>; Brian Croke, 25–63; Dilia N. Angelova.

⁵ Carolyn L. Connor, 479–527; Brian Croke, 25–63.

⁶ Carolyn L. Connor, 479–527; Brian Croke, 25–63.

⁷ Brian Croke, 25–63.

⁸ Carolyn L. Connor, 479–527; Brian Croke, 25–63; Dilia N. Angelova.

⁹ Jonathan Bardill. “The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus in Constantinople and the Monophysite Refugees,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 54 (2000): 1–11, doi: 10.2307/1291830; Carolyn L. Connor, 479–527; Brian Croke, 25–63

¹⁰ Carolyn L. Connor, 479–527; Brian Croke, 25–63.

to the construction of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus highlights the influence of an aristocratic woman that stemmed from her acts of religious patronage.

The location of the Church of Hagios Sergius and Bacchus in the Palace of Hormisdas and the ongoing theological conflict between the Monophysites and Orthodox Christians provides important historical context that may highlight the reason for its construction. Monophysite refugees first arrived in Constantinople after persecution in the eastern Mediterranean began in 521 after Emperor Justin I ended the Acacian Schism that brought the Byzantine Empire in line with beliefs of the Council of Chalcedon that Christ had a split divine and human nature.¹¹ According to John of Ephesus' *Lives of the Eastern Saints*, Theodora is said to have accommodated 500 Monophysite refugees in the Palace of Hormisdas, her and Justinian's living quarters before he ascended to the throne.¹² This occurred after Justinian and Theodora moved out into the imperial palace, but does not explicitly specify the building the refugees were housed in, labeling it only as a "martyrium".¹³ Cyril Mango asserted that John of Ephesus' reference must be the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus which was used to house the refugees of this conflict.¹⁴ However, the grandeur of the church and the exact timeline of events has led Richard Krauthmier to object to this theory, stating that the building's construction and the influx of Monophysite refugees into the Palace of Hormisdas were unrelated.¹⁵ Jonathan Bardill proposed an alternative theory that utilized pieces of the arguments from Mango and

¹¹ Jonathan Bardill. "The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus in Constantinople and the Monophysite Refugees," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 54 (2000): 1–11, doi: 10.2307/1291830.

¹² Jonathan Bardill, 1–11; Diliانا N Angelova. "CHURCH BUILDING AND FOUNDING," *Sacred Founders: Women, Men, and Gods in the Discourse of Imperial Founding, Rome through Early Byzantium* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2015), <http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1525/j.ctt19632rv.16>.

¹³ Jonathan Bardill, 1–11; Diliانا N Angelova. "CHURCH BUILDING AND FOUNDING," *Sacred Founders: Women, Men, and Gods in the Discourse of Imperial Founding, Rome through Early Byzantium* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2015), <http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1525/j.ctt19632rv.16>.

¹⁴ Cyril Mango. "The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus at Constantinople and The Alleged Traditions of Octagonal Palatine Churches," *JÖB* 21 (1972): 189-193; Cyril Mango. "The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus Once Again," *Byzantinische Zeitschrift* 68, no. 2 (1975): 385-392. doi:10.1515/byzs.1975.68.2.385.

¹⁵ Richard Krauthmier. "Again Saints Sergius and Bacchus at Constantinople," *JÖB* 23 (1974): 251-253.

Krauthmier. Monophysite refugees were housed in one of the halls of the Palace of Hormisdas during the early persecution from 521-530 and into the peaceful negotiations from 530-536.¹⁶ John of Ephesus documented that the location where the Monophysite monks were living collapsed, and a “vaulted structure” was built in replacement.¹⁷ Sure enough, the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus is a domed structure (Figure 1).¹⁸ Bardill theorizes that the church is the “vaulted structure” referred to by John of Ephesus, and since it was built during the period of peaceful negotiations and after the time when the monks were sheltered to protect them from persecution, it was a grand construction in an attempt to court the Monophysite monks.¹⁹

Theodora has significant influence in this chain of events. First, it is widely accepted that she was the one that established the Monophysite refugee community in the Palace of Hormisdas in 527, before the peaceful negotiations of 530-536.²⁰ Additionally, the dedicatory inscription in the Church of Saints Sergios and Bacchus declares that the “God-crowned” Theodora wields significant “power” and her “constant toil lies in unsparing efforts to nourish the destitute”.²¹ If Bardill’s theory holds, this characterization of the empress can be seen as an attempt to appeal to the refugees by imploring them to look at what she has provided them in terms of shelter and protection. Thus, Theodora is at the center of the construction of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus as she is the reason the Monophysites are there in the first place, and she allowed Justinian and the Byzantine state to make effective efforts to court this religious community.²²

¹⁶ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

¹⁷ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

¹⁸ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

¹⁹ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

²⁰ Dilia N Angelova. “CHURCH BUILDING AND FOUNDING,” *Sacred Founders: Women, Men, and Gods in the Discourse of Imperial Founding, Rome through Early Byzantium* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2015), <http://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1525/j.ctt19632rv.16>; John Meyendorff. “Justinian, the Empire and the Church,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 22 (1968): 43–60, doi: 10.2307/1291275; Jonathan Bardill 1-11.

²¹ Jonathan Bardill. “The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus in Constantinople and the Monophysite Refugees,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 54 (2000): 1–11, doi: 10.2307/1291830; Carolyn L. Connor. “THE EPIGRAM IN THE CHURCH OF HAGIOS POLYEUKTOS IN CONSTANTINOPLE AND ITS BYZANTINE RESPONSE,” *Byzantion* 69, no. 2 (1999): 479–527, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/44172500>; Dilia N. Angelova.

²² Dilia N. Angelova.

Theodora's power in the religious sphere can also be seen in events that transpired following her death in 548.²³ Orthodox Christians attempted to "sully" the image of the Monophysites, and during this campaign, a fire destroyed a significant portion of the grounds of the Palace of Hormisdas including another church, the Church of Saints Peter and Paul.²⁴ The Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus survived.²⁵ It is unclear what started this disaster, but as these events only transpired following the death of Theodora, it is clear that her presence, influence, and power protected the Monophysite community she and Justinian housed.²⁶ Regardless of which theory explains the construction of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, or whether they both hold some truth, it is evident that in the Byzantine Empire in Late Antiquity, several powerful women held influence that stemmed from the role they assumed in the religious sphere. Additionally, the theological conflict that resulted from a still evolving Christianity in the 6th century provides important contextualization that could have impacted the building of the church and other religious commissions of the time period.

The most striking feature on the exterior of the Church of Santa Sergius and Bacchus is the dome that rests upon its roof (Figure 1).²⁷ The structure is not hemispherical and instead has a hexadecagon base (Figure 2). Gray, triangular stone slabs are attached to the base and curved over to meet at a point (Figure 1). The dome is a central hallmark of Byzantine architectural style.²⁸ An example of this on a much larger scale is the structure atop the Hagia Sophia as seen in Figure 11 that followed the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus in the list of Justinian and

²³ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

²⁴ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

²⁵ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

²⁶ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

²⁷ "Constantinople, Church of SS. Sergius and Bacchus," Livius.org, Modified 22 September 2020, <https://www.livius.org/articles/place/constantinople-istanbul/constantinople-photos/constantinople-church-of-ss-sergius-and-bacchus/>

²⁸ John Meyendorff. "Justinian, the Empire and the Church," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 22 (1968): 43–60, doi: 10.2307/1291275.

Theodora's commissioned buildings.²⁹ The dome is directly over top of the central nave as seen in the ground plan in Figure 7 and the ground plan follows a basilica-like structure, though it deviates from the traditional style seen in the Roman Empire.³⁰ In the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, the two side aisles wrap around the entire circumference of the building breaking only for the apse and the main entryway. The nave is rectangular, but doesn't extend to the apse or the main entryway, and is instead isolated in the middle under the dome. This differs from the traditional Roman basilica where the side aisles are perfectly straight, and the nave is the same length but wider than the two adjacent sections, and connects to both the apse and the main entryway.³¹ Again, a comparison can be drawn between the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus and the Hagia Sophia as the latter implements the same basilica-like design on a much larger scale as seen in Figures 7 and 10.³² It is clear that Roman influence is present in Byzantine architecture, but it is adapted to create a unique visual style, likely to express power and identity of new imperial rulers in a new capital city and as Christianity continued to develop its optical identity in Eastern Europe.³³

The interior of the Church of Saints Sergios and Bacchus is one level in the central nave and the apse, and two levels in the side aisles and main entryway (Figures 2, 4, and 6). The central nave is located directly beneath the dome discussed earlier which is the highest point of the roof of the church. As it is only one level, verticality is emphasized as seen in Figures 2, 4

²⁹ Judith Herrin. "The Church of Hagia Sophia," *Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire*, 50–60. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2007), doi:10.2307/j.ctv6zdbvf.10.

³⁰ Valentin Müller. "The Roman Basilica," *American Journal of Archaeology* 41, no. 2 (1937): 250–61, doi:10.2307/498415; "Constantinople, Church of SS. Sergius and Bacchus"

³¹ Valentin Müller, 250–61; "Constantinople, Church of SS. Sergius and Bacchus"

³² Judith Herrin. "The Church of Hagia Sophia," *Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire*, 50–60. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2007), doi:10.2307/j.ctv6zdbvf.10; "Constantinople, Church of SS. Sergius and Bacchus"

³³ John Meyendorff. "Justinian, the Empire and the Church," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 22 (1968): 43–60, doi: 10.2307/1291275; Valentin Müller. "The Roman Basilica," *American Journal of Archaeology* 41, no. 2 (1937): 250–61, doi:10.2307/498415; Judith Herrin. "The Church of Hagia Sophia," *Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire*, 50–60. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2007), doi:10.2307/j.ctv6zdbvf.10.

and 6 which document this area. The roof over the apse has a similar height to the rest of the building, but it does have a half hemispherical dome (Figure 1) that protrudes upwards as viewed from the exterior. Similar to the central nave, but to a lesser extent, verticality was emphasized in its height and single level configuration. The underside of these domes would likely have included Christian iconography when it was first constructed and up until the Ottoman takeover in 1453 and subsequent conversion of the church into a mosque.³⁴ The interior decoration and its transformation will be discussed in more detail below. Again, The Hagia Sophia is similarly oriented on its interior with multiple levels in the side aisles and one in the central nave (Figure 12), and as it is far larger than the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, the sense of verticality is even greater.³⁵

The dome rests upon a series of rounded arches that section off the interior of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus (Figure 2). This includes the apse and the main entryway (Figures 2 and 4), and it creates in effect portals inside the church that emphasize the idea of crossing over into the confluence of the holy and earthly realms when making one's way up to the altar or into the central nave, respectively. Sections of the side aisles are also created by the sequence of rounded arches which does not appear to have any greater meaning than aesthetic continuity (Figure 6). The use of rounded arches (Figures 6 and 9) is another example of the Roman influence present in Byzantine architecture as these features were found in ancient basilicas which were the inspiration for church design in the Late Antiquity.³⁶ However, Roman basilicas typically arranged rounded arches in a straight line as opposed to the circular orientation present

³⁴ Brian Croke. "Justinian, Theodora, and the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 60 (2006): 25–63. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25046210>; Judith Herrin, 50-60

³⁵ Judith Herrin, 50-60; Brian Croke 25-63.

³⁶ Valentin Müller. "The Roman Basilica," *American Journal of Archaeology* 41, no. 2 (1937): 250–61, doi:10.2307/498415.

in the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus and the Hagia Sophia.³⁷ Again, the Byzantine architectural style is heavily influenced by Roman design, but adapted to give it a clear identity.

Inside the two-tiered side aisle sections there are a series of small arches created by gray stone columns and adorned with Theodosian capitals inscribed with Justinian and Theodora's initials (Figures 5, 6, and 9).³⁸ Theodosian capitals are adorned with the shape of bent leaves, giving them a very naturalistic appearance.³⁹ This style was pioneered by Emperor Theodosius, and it became a component of the emerging Byzantine architectural style.⁴⁰ Theodosian capitals are used in both the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus and the Hagia Sophia (Figures 5 and 13).⁴¹ Through the inscription of his and Theodora's initials on these capitals, he associated the emerging Byzantine style with his reign and thus established and legitimized his political and religious power as head of the empire and head of the church.⁴² The inscription styles of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus and the Hagia Sophia differ as seen in Figures 5 and 13, as they employed the square and cruciform type, respectively.⁴³ This difference between the two highlights how the Byzantine art and architectural style was still evolving in the 6th century in the centuries following the shift of authority in the Mediterranean from Rome to Constantinople. Additionally, the discrepancy in inscription style has allowed the Church of Saints Sergius and

³⁷ Valentin Müller, 250-61

³⁸ Brian Croke. "Justinian, Theodora, and the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 60 (2006): 25-63. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25046210>; "Constantinople, Church of SS. Sergius and Bacchus," Livius.org, Modified 22 September 2020, <https://www.livius.org/articles/place/constantinople-istanbul/constantinople-photos/constantinople-church-of-ss-sergius-and-bacchus/>

³⁹ John Meyendorff. "Justinian, the Empire and the Church," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 22 (1968): 43-60, doi: 10.2307/1291275; Brian Croke, 25-63.

⁴⁰ John Meyendorff, 43-60, Brian Croke 25-63.

⁴¹ Judith Herrin. "The Church of Hagia Sophia," *Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire*, 50-60. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2007), doi:10.2307/j.ctv6zdbvf.10; John Meyendorff, 43-60, Brian Croke 25-63.

⁴² John Meyendorff, 43-60, Brian Croke 25-63; Judith Herrin, 50-60.

⁴³ Jonathan Bardill. "The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus in Constantinople and the Monophysite Refugees," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 54 (2000): 1-11, doi: 10.2307/1291830; Brian Croke. "Justinian, Theodora, and the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 60 (2006): 25-63. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25046210>.

Bacchus to be dated to before roughly 532 because the cruciform type monogram would have been used after it was introduced in the Hagia Sophia.⁴⁴ Religious patronage played a significant role in Christianity in the Late Antiquity, so those who funded these projects wanted to make it known.⁴⁵ These commissions of art and architecture such as churches were seen as offerings to important figures such as God, Jesus, or the Virgin Mary.⁴⁶ This created a sort of contract between the person that created or funded the project and the powers that be in Christianity for eternal salvation.⁴⁷ Thus, it was important for Theodora and Justinian to mark their acts of religious patronage to get credit for them in the eyes of holy Christian figures.

The dedicatory inscription in the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus was carved in Greek into the stone that separates the first and second level of the side aisle (Figure 3).⁴⁸

Translated, it reads:

*Other sovereigns have honoured dead men whose labour was unprofitable, but our sceptered Justinian, fostering piety, honors with a splendid abode the Servant of Christ, Begetter of all things, Sergius; whom not the burning breath of fire, nor the sword, nor any other constraints of torments disturbed; but who endured to be slain for the sake of Christ, the God, gaining by his blood heaven as his home. May he in all things guard the rule of the sleepless sovereign and increase the power of the God-crowned Theodora whose mind is adorned with piety, whose constant toil lies in unsparing efforts to nourish the destitute.*⁴⁹

⁴⁴ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11; Brian Croke 25-63.

⁴⁵ Carolyn L. Connor. "THE EPIGRAM IN THE CHURCH OF HAGIOS POLYEUKTOS IN CONSTANTINOPLE AND ITS BYZANTINE RESPONSE," *Byzantion* 69, no. 2 (1999): 479-527, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/44172500>.

⁴⁶ Carolyn L. Connor, 479-527.

⁴⁷ John Meyendorff. "Justinian, the Empire and the Church," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 22 (1968): 43-60, doi: 10.2307/1291275; Carolyn L. Connor, 479-527.

⁴⁸ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11

⁴⁹ Jonathan Bardill. "The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus in Constantinople and the Monophysite Refugees," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 54 (2000): 1-11, doi: 10.2307/1291830.

From this inscription, the role of patronage in the religious, political, and social spheres is evident, especially when considering the ideological pervasiveness of Christianity in the Byzantine Empire. As the church is an offering to the Saint Sergius “who endured to be slain for the sake of Christ, the God”, Justinian and Theodora establish a contract whereby they expect that Sergius will “guard the rule” of Justinian and “increase the power of the God-crowned Theodora”.⁵⁰ Thus, it is apparent that acts of patronage played a significant role in Byzantine Christianity as honoring important figures in turn boosted the religious standing of those who commissioned these pieces. Additionally, the inscription characterizes Justinian as “fostering piety” and Theodora as “adorned with piety”.⁵¹ Commissioning religious offerings allowed patrons to promote and advertise themselves as ideal Christians.⁵² As Christianity was the dominant ideology of Late Antiquity in Byzantium, this mechanism also impacted one’s political and social standing.⁵³ In the case of the church’s inscription, the imperial couple sought to “guard the rule” and “increase the power” that they enjoyed.⁵⁴ Political dominion was thus legitimized by religion which can also be seen in the description of Theodora as “God-crowned”.⁵⁵ Socially, Justinian and Theodora portrayed themselves as righteous rulers. The inscription describes Theodora as someone “whose constant toil lies in unsparing efforts to nourish the destitute”.⁵⁶ Additionally, Justinian is conveyed as “sleepless” which characterizes him working hard in his role as “sovereign” and thus a rightful ruler.⁵⁷ As caring for the poor and marginalized people in

⁵⁰ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

⁵¹ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

⁵² John Meyendorff. “Justinian, the Empire and the Church,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 22 (1968): 43–60, doi: 10.2307/1291275.

⁵³ Carolyn L. Connor. “THE EPIGRAM IN THE CHURCH OF HAGIOS POLYEUKTOS IN CONSTANTINOPLE AND ITS BYZANTINE RESPONSE,” *Byzantion* 69, no. 2 (1999): 479–527, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/44172500>; John Meyendorff, 43-60

⁵⁴ Carolyn L. Connor, 479-527.

⁵⁵ Jonathan Bardill. “The Church of Sts. Sergius and Bacchus in Constantinople and the Monophysite Refugees,” *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 54 (2000): 1–11, doi: 10.2307/1291830.

⁵⁶ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

⁵⁷ Jonathan Bardill, 1-11.

society is a core idea in the Christian faith, these depictions of the imperial couple not only serve to establish themselves as important religious figures, but also to gain favor of the Byzantine population. The pervasiveness of Christian ideology in the Eastern Mediterranean in Late Antiquity resulted in the religious, political, and social power that Justinian and Theodora sought and derived from the inscription.

Presently, as stated before, the building is a mosque due to the Ottoman conquest of Constantinople in 1453.⁵⁸ As a result, the interior decoration was significantly altered, and a minaret was added to the grounds. The imagery lining the walls is abstract, geometric, and floral, and does not portray any religious figures as are seen in the remaining Christian decorations in the Hagia Sophia (Figure 14).⁵⁹ As Justinian and Theodora commissioned both churches, there were a significant number of other similarities, and Christian iconography was a big part of religious tradition before and after the 6th century, it can be concluded that in all likelihood there were internal and external designs that resembled that in Figure 14. Knowing the original interior decoration would allow for further analysis of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus in its Byzantine form and see the ways Christian iconography was used and the impacts this has on the aforementioned themes.

Despite being less known than its sister the Hagia Sophia, the Church of Saint Sergius and Bacchus carries significant importance. The motivation for its construction as well as the dedicatory inscription reveals the role that important women such as Theodora and Anicia Juliana played especially religiously in the Byzantine Empire during Justinian's rule. The ongoing theological conflict between the Monophysites and Orthodox Christians provides an

⁵⁸ Brian Croke. "Justinian, Theodora, and the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus," *Dumbarton Oaks Papers* 60 (2006): 25–63. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25046210>.

⁵⁹ Judith Herrin. "The Church of Hagia Sophia," *Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire*, 50–60. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2007), doi:10.2307/j.ctv6zdbvf.10.

important contextual background for the construction of the church. Whether or not this theological schism played the primary role in the building of the Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, its location in the Palace of Hormisdas where Monophysite refugees were housed and the characterization of Theodora in the dedicatory inscription shows the role that religious conflict played on architecture. Finally, the use of a distinct architectural style in comparison with the Hagia Sophia as well as the church's purpose highlights the religious, political, and social power derived from acts of patronage in the Byzantine Empire.

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Figure 1: Exterior view, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532

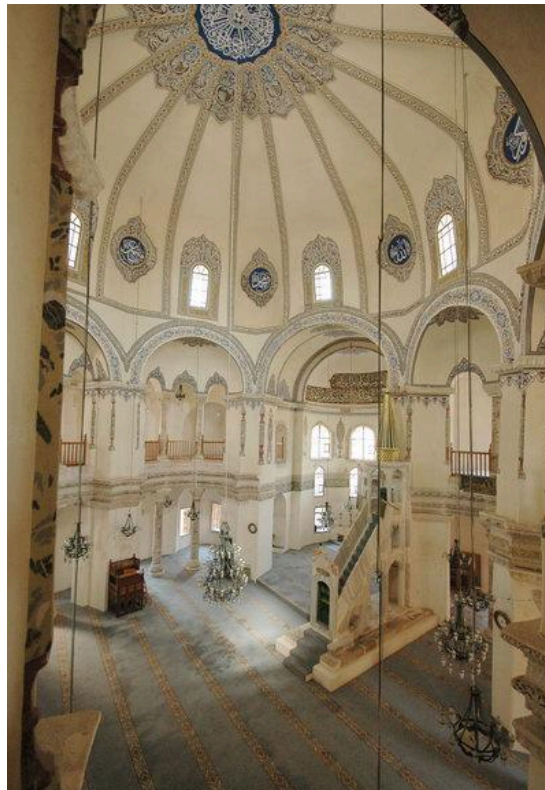


Figure 2: Central nave, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532



Figure 3: Surviving Greek dedicatory inscription, translation: “May God expand the power of Theodora, crowned by God” (top) and “...continued efforts to feed those without possessions...” (bottom), Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532.



Figure 4: Apse, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532



Figure 5: Theodosian column capitals inscribed with the initials of Empress Theodora and Emperor Justinian I, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532.

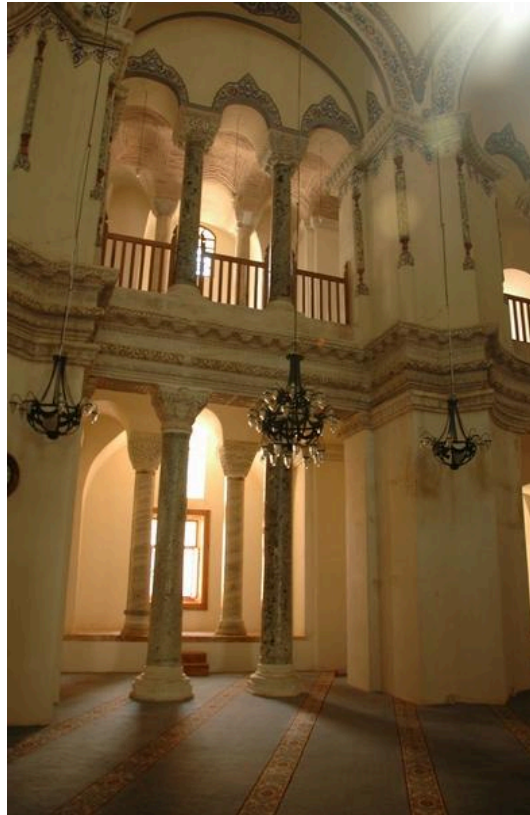


Figure 6: Side aisle, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532

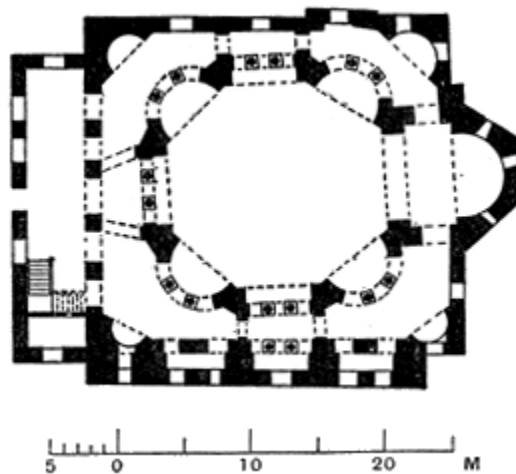


Figure 7: Ground plan, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532.



Figure 8: Apse, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus, ca. 527-532



Figure 9: Columns, column capitals, and rounded arches, Church of Saints Sergius and Bacchus,
ca. 527-532

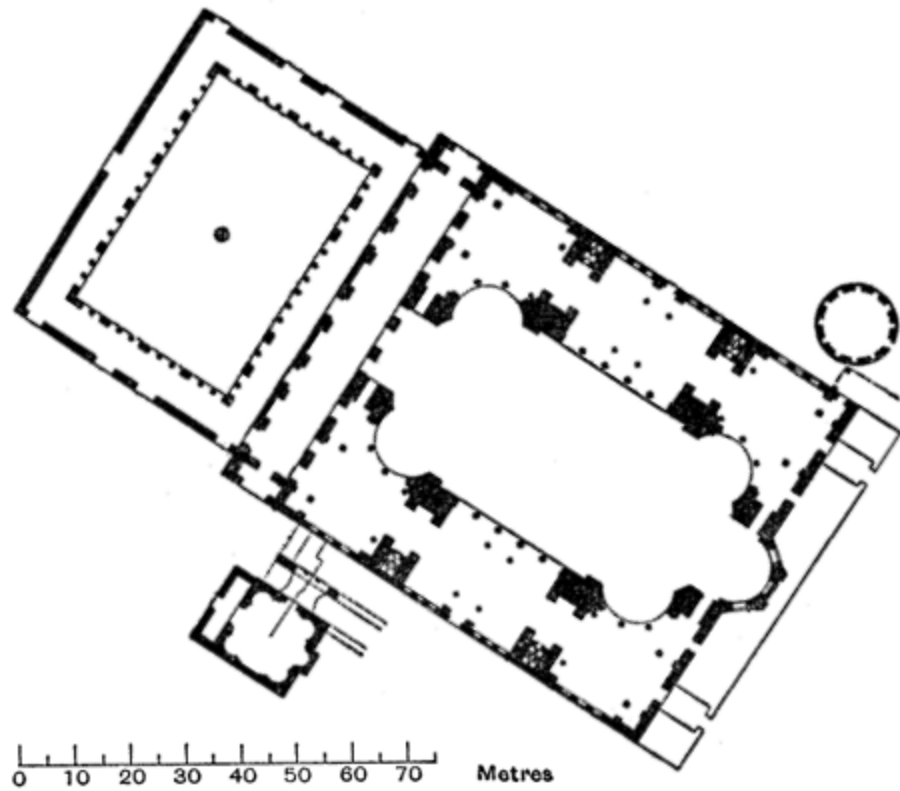


Figure 10: Ground plan, Hagia Sophia, 537



Figure 11: Exterior view, Hagia Sophia, 537



Figure 12: Central nave, Hagia Sophia, 537



Figure 13: Theodosian column capitals inscribed with Empress Theodora and Emperor Justinian I's initials, Hagia Sophia, 537



Figure 14: Original Christian decoration over Splendid Gate, Hagia Sophia, 537